

HEADY MIX
Ankon Mitra at his studio in Okhla, Delhi, surrounded by prototypes of beautifully folded pieces in varying materials, from metal and paper to plant leather

A Dialogue Between Two Cities

Mitra's evolution mirrors the very buildings he works on. Trained as a modernist, his early work had clean lines with very little ornamentation. However, the ghost of Parisian Baroque, its ornate, over-the-top richness, lingered in his mind for years. "Now materials and materiality have themselves become an opportunity for creating ornamentation." For the Mumbai project, this manifested as a high-stakes race against time. Mitra had to marry the exacting standards of French luxury with Indian grit. The brief was strict: the French tricolours of red, white and blue. "It was hectic," Mitra admits. "You don't always get those exact shades in off-the-shelf paper." When global shipping timelines threatened the project, his team pivoted to a bespoke, hands-on approach: hand-dyeing paper to achieve the precise depth of French Blue and Flag Red.

The Secret Indian Soul

While the facade screams Parisian chic, a closer look reveals a subtext that is purely Indic. Mitra didn't just want to paint the store in foreign hues; he wanted to tuck a local narrative into the geometry. "My tech-